RELEASE OF NAVY VETERANS

A DIPLOMATIC COUP

By Pradip R. Sagar



HOMECOMING Six of the eight Indian Navy veterans released by Qatar



It is a *ghar wapsi* New Delhi had been working on with bated breath for months—ever since news got out that eight former Indian Navy men were facing a dire fate in Qatar. It was on February 11 that everyone finally breathed easy, as the Narendra Modi government secured a major diplomatic breakthrough. All suspense over their fate ended as the eight navy veterans were released in Doha, where they were being held in captivity since August 2022. Like their arrest on alleged espionage charges, the release was also kept under wraps till the final moment. It was in the early hours of Sunday that the Qatari authorities asked the eight men to pack their bags. First, they were taken to the Indian embassy, and then to the airport, where seven of them boarded a special flight that landed in Delhi at 2 am the next day. All this while not even their family members had any knowledge of their homecoming. Some had even lost hope of their release, even after their death sentence was commuted in December last year. (The eighth navy veteran is still in Doha, reportedly awaiting completion of formalities.)

The importance that Modi attaches to this development became apparent as the ministry of external affairs (MEA) made a last-minute announcement of his plan to visit Doha on February 14, after his two-day scheduled visit to the UAE. This marks the PM's second visit to Qatar since 2014. South Block mandarins say it has never been easy to negotiate with Qatar, which is known to act in an "arbitrary" and "secretive" manner. Though barring the execution of a Nepali migrant in 2021, no other death penalty has been carried out in the Gulf nation in two decades, given the serious charges against the Indians—spying for Israel, say sources—nothing could be left to chance.

So, New Delhi employed a multi-pronged strategy, blending overt diplomacy spearheaded by external affairs minister S. Jaishankar with behind-the-scenes efforts led by National Security Advisor (NSA) Ajit Doval—all of it "personally supervised" by Modi. India's significant investments in enhancing ties with Qatar and other key players in West Asia, including Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Oman and Kuwait, are also believed to have played a role in influencing the favourable outcome. Talking of a possible quid pro quo, some point to the $78 billion (Rs 6.48 lakh crore) long-term deal signed by India's Petronet LNG—just a week before the release—to extend liquefied natural gas imports from Qatar for another 20 years till 2048. (The Gulf nation is a major contributor to India's energy security, accounting for almost half of India's LNG imports.)

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Another key persona grata in India's diplomatic efforts was ambassador Vipul, who was appointed to the Indian embassy in Doha in June 2023. But even before that, the seasoned